VENISON AND TEPARY BEAN CHILI

serves 8 to 10

Warmly spicy and comforting, this chili gets its robust flavors from both fresh and dried chiles and, of course, ground venison. (You can use any type of lean ground meat here.)

Tepary beans are drought tolerant and have an especially dense, meaty texture. If you substitute other beans for them, you might need to adjust the cooking time a bit, since tepary beans typically take longer to cook, even after you soak them overnight.

To soften the heat of the chili a bit, you can serve it with Corn Mush (page 147). And though avocados are not native to the region, the avocado crema (Crema de Aguacate, page 237) is also delicious with this.

- 1 cup dried tepary beans (any color), soaked overnight and drained
- Sea salt
- 2 guajillo chiles
- 2 morita chiles
- 1 ancho chile
- 4 tablespoons sunflower oil
- 2 pounds ground venison or other ground meat
- 1 medium yellow onion, chopped
- 1 poblano chile, stemmed, seeded, and chopped
- 5 garlic cloves, minced
- 2 pounds fresh tomatoes, cored and chopped
- 3 cups Rich Bison or Other Game Stock (page 41) or other meat stock
- 1 tablespoon cider vinegar
- 1 tablespoon honey
- Corn Mush (page 147), for serving

In a medium saucepan, combine the soaked beans with water to cover by 1 to 2 inches. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat, then reduce the heat to medium-low and simmer for 1½ to 2 hours, until the beans are tender. Add water as needed to keep them well covered. Remove from the heat, season them with salt, and let stand for 20 minutes.

Meanwhile, heat a large cast-iron skillet or a comal over medium-high heat. Toast the guajillo, morita, and ancho chiles for 1 to 2 minutes, turning frequently, until they're pliable and fragrant. Transfer to a work surface to cool, then discard their stems and seeds.

Place the toasted chiles in a medium saucepan, add 3 cups water, and bring to a boil over high heat. Turn off the heat and let stand for 30 minutes, then transfer the chiles and their cooking liquid to a blender and puree. Push the puree through a fine-mesh sieve into a bowl.

In a large heavy saucepan, skillet, or Dutch oven, heat 2 tablespoons of the oil over medium-high heat until shimmering. Add the venison and season with salt. Cook for about 5 minutes, breaking up the meat with a spoon, until evenly browned and cooked through. Using a slotted spoon, transfer to a plate.

Add the remaining 2 tablespoons of oil to the pan and heat over medium heat. Add the onion and poblano and cook for about 8 minutes, or until softened.

Add the garlic and cook for about 1 minute, stirring, until fragrant and soft. Stir in the tomatoes and cook until they start to release their liquid, then add the cooked beans and cooked venison as well as the chile puree and the stock. Bring to a boil over medium-high heat, then reduce the heat to medium-low and simmer for about 40 minutes, or until the chili is thick and flavorful. Stir in the cider vinegar and honey. Taste and season with more salt, as needed.

Serve the chili with corn mush.

CORN MUSH

serves 4

Southerners call it grits. Italians, polenta. And in English, we call it corn mush, although it goes by many different names across Turtle Island.

In places where people grew corn, simple corn porridges from dried cornmeal were the base of many meals. Today, they are still a comfort food for Indigenous peoples—sometimes the first food we eat as babies and our last food as elders.

The corn used for mush can be white, yellow, blue, green, red, or even multicolored. Sometimes the cornmeal is roasted first to give it a toasty flavor.

The corn for this dish is not always nixtamalized, but some people add alkalizing agents as they cook their mush to enhance the flavor and soften the texture. For example, in the Southwest, the Diné (Navajo) cook their blue corn mush with juniper ash. (As with nixtamalization, adding an alkalizing agent also boosts the corn's nutritional value.)

In the Southeast, there is also a long Indigenous tradition of sometimes eating (or drinking) thick porridges of soured corn, known as sofkee, which are made with green corn or nixtamalized corn and left to ferment for a little while.

For something drinkable, like an atole (see page 270), fine-grind masa harina is mixed with a higher ratio of liquid.

1 teaspoon culinary ash (optional)

1 cup medium-grind cornmeal (any color)

¼ teaspoon sea salt

In a medium pot, bring 2 cups water to a simmer over medium-high heat. Add the ash if you're using it.

In a bowl, whisk together the cornmeal and salt and then whisk in 2 cups water, making sure to dissolve any lumps. Carefully and gradually add the cornmeal slurry to the simmering water while whisking. Cook for 30 to 45 minutes, stirring occasionally, until the porridge thickens enough that it starts to hold the streaks of the whisk or spoon you use to stir. Taste the mush and if you like the texture (see Note), it's ready to serve. If it seems like the corn needs more softening, continue cooking, adding more water if necessary. Depending on the corn, this might take minutes, or in some cases, an hour or more. It's a matter of your preference and how smooth a texture you want to achieve.

Serve hot.

Note: *When making corn mush, the ratio of liquid to cornmeal can vary immensely based on the texture of the cornmeal grind and the consistency of the mush you prefer. For example, to create a stiff mush, you'll use 1 cup medium-grind cornmeal to 3 cups water. For something looser, you'd increase the water to 5 or 6 cups. The recipe here starts with 4 cups liquid, but feel free to adjust as you like.*